

Vocabulary Development: ANTONYMS OF WORDS: Words opposite in meaning.

Antonym is a word which is the opposite in meaning of another word. It shows the relationship in contrast. Antonyms and their correct usage. It is important to note that context clues help in determining the appropriate meaning of any word. e.g. Mary is fair in complexion. The appropriate antonym for “fair” is “dark” and not “black” because there is no “black” complexion. Although, “black” is the antonym of “fair”, it does not apply in this context. Therefore one should choose antonyms or opposite of words by examining the contextual meaning. Antonyms can be formed in three ways

- a. By adding prefixes to the root word
- b. By changing suffix
- c. By changing a word entirely
- a. By adding prefix

un – seen – unseen

able – unable

do – undo

stable – unstable etc.

im – possible – impossible

moral – immoral

pure – impure

mortal – immortal

in – visible – invisible

discipline – indiscipline

active – inactive

audible – inaudible

il – legal – illegal

legitimate – illegitimate

legible – illegible

dis – able – disable

courage – discourage

organize – disorganize

unity – disunity

b. By changing suffix. Examples

Useful – useless

careful – careless

doubtful – doubtless

needful – needless

merciful – merciless

c. By changing a word entirely to another word.

deplete – replenish

smooth – rough

bold – timid

temporary – permanent

gently – roughly

dead – alive

float – sink

always – never

friendly – hostile

cheap – expensive/costly

d. Formation of antonyms by changing the prefix e.g.

Ascend – Descend

Export – Import

External – Internal

Prefix – Suffix

Encourage – Discourage

Construction – Destruction

Prenatal – Postnatal

Superior – Inferior

Enthroned – Dethroned

Renowned – Unknown

Assignment

Write out the antonyms of these words : humble, eager, considerate, extravagant, flattered.

Reference

Basic English Grammar for Schools and Colleges, by Chidinma C. Nduaguibe

Complete English Course for Senior Secondary Schools, by Ukamaka Chioma Ibe Ph.D.

